# THRONE OF ASHES

*Volume 1: The Cursed Playmate*

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Throne of Ashes · Volume 1: The Cursed Playmate

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CHAPTER 1

# The Wish Beneath the Cherry Blossoms

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They say gods don't make mistakes.

I've had a lot of time to think about that line since. Mostly at night, on a reed mat, in a palace where most people would prefer me dead by the end of the week. I've decided it's true, which is worse. A mistake you could appeal.

What I asked for was to be ten again.

What I got was a rope on my wrists, a hall full of gold, and a king younger than me deciding whether I'd see the morning.

But that's later. First there was a Tuesday, and a tree.

◆

JAPAN. SPRING. A TUESDAY.

My parents were obsessed with history.

I mean that as a diagnosis, not a compliment. Other kids' fathers had a team. Mine had a dynasty. The Eighteenth, specifically, which he'd tell you was the greatest run of rulers any country has produced, and then he'd tell you why, and you'd miss your train.

My mother was quieter about it, but she was the one who taped the chart over my bed when I was six. Ahmose at the top, Horemheb at the bottom, and all the way down, in her small handwriting, the dates. Not the dates they were born. The dates they came to the throne and the dates they died. She didn't think a child needed the middle part.

I could read that chart before I could read a clock. I'm eighteen now and I still can't see the number nineteen without thinking *that's how old he was.*

Anyway. That's the kind of house it was.

It burned down three years ago, in March, at about two in the morning. Somebody poured something through the letter slot and lit it. The police used the word *arson* on the first day and the word *ongoing* for about a year after that, and then they stopped using words.

I was the one who got out.

◆

The cherry road is not the fast way to school. It's the way you take if you don't want to see anyone from your class before the bell, and it costs you about nine minutes.

I know because I timed it, the spring after the fire, with the stopwatch on my phone. That's the kind of thing you do when you need to be in charge of one small thing.

I take it every day now. Nine minutes is cheap.

The trees are old. They lean in from both sides until the lane is a tunnel, and in the first week of April the tunnel is pink, and the pavement under it is pink, and the gutters are pink. A stranger would say it's beautiful. It is. I've just seen it enough that it's also only the way to school.

It rained last night. The petals have glued themselves to the wet concrete in a pattern that looks like someone trying to spell something and giving up.

My bag is heavy on one shoulder, mostly past-paper books, with my fencing jacket folded on top because I keep meaning to return it to the club and keep not doing it.

My phone goes off in my blazer pocket. One short buzz, then another.

I don't take it out. I know the shape of what's on there without looking. The class group chat doing its countdown to the entrance exams. A mail from the university where my parents used to teach, confirming, with what I can only assume is a straight face, that they've received my application to study history.

And Soren.

My brother writes on the first of the month. He's in Osaka with our uncle, who offered to take me too and was visibly relieved when I said no. Soren's message this month begins *It's three years on Sunday*, and that's all the preview shows, and that's all I've read.

Thirty-one steps from the corner to the first lamppost. I don't do this on purpose anymore. It just happens.

My reflection keeps pace with me along the puddles. Black uniform with the collar hooked. Black hair that wants cutting. A face my homeroom teacher once described in a report as *composed*, which is a word teachers use when they can't tell what you're thinking and have decided that's your fault.

There's a white line through my left eyebrow where a foil snapped at a tournament when I was twelve. The piece went past my eye close enough that I felt the air move. I stood at the mirror a long time that night, feeling lucky.

I'm not sure I've felt it since. Lucky. I'd have to check.

◆

"You're early."

Mrs. Hayashi runs the tea shop at the top of the slope, and she sweeps in front of it every morning in a pale blue apron, as if the petals were a private matter between her and the trees. She's about seventy and comes up to my shoulder. The broom is taller than she is.

"Couldn't sleep," I say.

"You never sleep. You're grey. Look at you."

She looks at me, since I'm apparently not going to. Then she props the broom against the wall and wipes her hands on the apron, which is what she does before saying something she's rehearsed.

"Your mother's books came."

I don't say anything.

"The order from the dealer in Kyoto. Six volumes. He had trouble finding the fourth." She says it briskly, like a shopkeeper, which is kind of her. "I had them put in my name, after. I didn't know what else to do with the account. They're in the back. I'll wrap them."

Six books. My mother ordered them in February, three years ago, and talked about them at dinner, and I can't remember a single title, because I was fifteen and it was dinner.

I take out my wallet. There's one note in it, a ten-thousand-yen bill folded in half and in half again, which I've carried since New Year for a reason I've since forgotten.

"How much was it?"

"Put that away."

"Mrs. Hayashi."

"After school," she says. "Come in the back way and I'll give you tea, and you'll carry them home properly in a bag, not in the rain like a lunatic. Go."

I put the bill in the breast pocket of my blazer, behind my student ID, over my heart, where I'll feel it and remember. Then I bow to her, properly, and she flaps a hand at me, and I go on down the slope.

Behind me the broom starts again. It has a rhythm like someone breathing in their sleep.

◆

The oldest tree is halfway down.

It's twice the girth of the others and leans so far over the lane that the city put a yellow sign on it once, years ago, and then apparently thought better of cutting it down. The roots have come up through the pavement and split around a little stone shrine at the base, the size of a mailbox, with a door that was sealed with grey mortar before anyone alive can remember.

There's a mark cut over the door. A circle with one line through it, straight down from the top. I used to think it was a clock face with the hands gone. My mother, when I was small and asked, said she wasn't sure, and I remember being surprised, because she was sure about everything.

Mrs. Hayashi sweeps the shrine too. Every morning. I asked her why once and she said, "Somebody should," which isn't an answer.

Every morning the old tree drops the same low branch across the pavement, and every morning somebody has to step over it.

I step over it.

Across the lane, a knot of kids from the elementary school are racing each other to the corner. Yellow caps bobbing, somebody's bag coming open, everyone shrieking. The smallest one, a boy of nine or ten, is trying to catch petals in his mouth and failing, mostly because he's laughing too hard to close it.

He's wearing a blue shirt with red sleeves.

I had that shirt. Not one like it. That one. My mother bought it in a museum gift shop the summer I turned ten, because I'd got chocolate ice cream down the front of the one I came in, and I wore it until the sleeves were halfway up my forearms.

That was the trip where my father stood me in front of the gold mask and said, "He was king when he was your age, Kael. Nine years old. Think about that." And I thought about it so hard I had a nightmare.

The boy in the blue shirt trips over his own feet, sits down hard on the wet pavement, and laughs even louder, head back, with his whole body. His friends run back to haul him up.

I'd give a great deal, right now, to laugh like that about anything.

They go around the corner and the lane is quiet. My phone buzzes again. I can feel the folded bill in my pocket, and under it my heart doing its ordinary work, and I'm so tired of being the one who's left that I say it out loud without quite deciding to.

"I wish I was ten again. Life was so much simpler."

The branches over my head stop moving.

I don't mean they go still. There's no wind to stop. I mean the petals that were falling stop falling, all of them, a few thousand points of pink hanging in the air between me and the trees, the way a photograph hangs. One is a hand's width from my face. I can see the little notch at the end of it.

I think, very clearly: *that isn't how anything works.*

**CRACK.**

It comes up through the soles of my shoes. The shrine's mortar splits with a sound like a knuckle. The roots lift the pavement in a slab, and the oldest tree on the cherry road tears loose from the ground and leans. Slow at first.

Then not slow.

I see it coming. Every coach I ever had said that about me, that I see the attack before it starts.

Seeing it is not the same as moving.

*Of course,* I think. *Of course it's this one.*

The trunk comes down.

It doesn't hurt. It's just weight, an impossible amount of it, and the smell of wet bark and rain, and a long way off, up the hill, the sound of a broom stopping.

Somewhere under me, my phone is still buzzing.

Then it's not.

NOWHERE. NO TIME.

I come to on my back with grit between my teeth.

There's no sand on the cherry road. I know every square metre of that road. So before I open my eyes I already know I'm not on it, and I lie there with them shut, checking my body one piece at a time. Toes. Knees. The ribs, which should be flat. The spine, which should be a story doctors tell each other later.

Everything answers. Nothing hurts.

I'd have preferred pain. Pain means a hospital.

The sky, when I look, has no colour. Not dark, not light. The colour of the inside of your eyelids. It goes on in every direction without a sun or a seam, and under it, to the horizon, there are dunes.

The sand is pale and very fine. I pick up a handful and let it run, and halfway through I stop, because it isn't sand.

I'm holding a hairpin. A baby tooth. A key, the small flat kind, for a lock that's long since been changed. Grains of things, worn down.

The whole dune is like that, and the one past it, and the ones past those. Bigger things poke out here and there the way bones do in a real desert. A bicycle with the chain off. A dog's leash with no dog.

In a dip just below me, a wedding ring catches the no-light, and while I'm looking at it, it goes. It doesn't sink. It fades, like a photograph left in a shop window, until there's only the dip.

Three metres off, half buried, is a pair of reading glasses with the left arm mended with tape.

I know that tape. I did it. I was eleven and he was going to buy new ones and I said I could fix them, and he wore them taped for four years out of a stubbornness I've since recognised in myself.

I don't pick them up. I think I'm afraid they'll fade while I'm holding them.

◆

"You died, Kael."

I don't jump. I'd like to say that's composure. It's probably that there's nothing left in me to jump with.

He's sitting on the crest of the next dune, where a second ago there was only dune, like a man on a wall waiting for a bus that stopped running years ago.

I say *he*. I'm not sure. He's tall and narrow and wrapped in something pale that might be linen, and he's made of dust. The kind you see turning in a shaft of sun through a dirty window, gold and never still. There's a face. It keeps almost arriving. The dust gets as far as a brow, a cheekbone, the line of a mouth, and thinks better of it.

His voice is dry and not loud. Pages turning in a library after closing.

"The tree was older than you," he says. "Roots like that go a long way. It fell. That's all it was."

"Who are you?"

"Whoever you like. People have been very creative about it." One hand, or the idea of one, takes in the dunes. "This is mine. All of it. Everything that's finished. Somebody has to keep it."

"The past."

"If you need a job title."

I look at the ring-shaped dip in the sand.

"That's what it looks like," he says, following my eye, "when the last person who remembers something stops. From this side. You'd be surprised how quiet it is."

◆

I should be screaming. I'm aware of that. There's a part of me doing it, a long way down, with its hands over its face.

But the part on top is the part that sat in a police station at four in the morning answering questions about accelerants while a woman in a cardigan kept offering me a juice box. That part learned something that spring: if you go cold enough, you can get through nearly anything, and worry about what it cost you later.

So I go cold.

"If I'm dead," I say, "why are we talking?"

"Because you asked me for something."

"I didn't ask you for anything."

"You stood on my step and said it out loud." He tilts his almost-head. "The little house under the tree. With the door. People used to leave things. Rice, mostly. Nobody's left anything in a long time, but the old woman sweeps, which I appreciate more than she knows."

The shrine. The circle with the line through it. A clock with its hands gone, my six-year-old self decided, and was wrong.

"I wasn't talking to you. I wasn't talking to anyone. People *say* that."

"*I wish I was ten again. Life was so much simpler.*"

He gives it back to me in my own voice, and it's worse than I remember. It sounds like whining.

"You said it on my step, at an hour when I happened to be listening, which is rarer than you'd think. I've decided to say yes."

"You can't."

"Then you should be more careful where you stand."

He holds up his hand, and there's an hourglass in it that wasn't there before. A small one. Clouded glass, a frame of dark wood worn pale at the corners. The sand inside is the same gold as him.

"You'll be a child," he says. "Ten, since you were specific. Somewhere that's finished. I'll choose where. Two years."

He turns the hourglass over, and a grain lets go with a sound I've never heard anywhere else.

*Tick.*

"Two floods of the river. When the second one goes down, I take my hand off you, and you go back exactly where you were."

Where I was. On my back on the wet pavement under eighty years of cherry tree, with my phone going.

"You're lending me two years and then sending me back to die."

"You're already dead. That part's done." He says it kindly, which I don't forgive him for. "I'm lending you some time I happen to have. It isn't really mine to lend. Try not to waste it."

"And if I don't want it."

He doesn't answer that. The sand keeps falling.

◆

"Then tell me the rules."

My hands have started to shake. I put them under my arms so he won't see, which is stupid, because I don't know what he sees.

"Where. When. How do I eat. What happens if I—"

"They'll understand you, and you'll understand them. It'll feel like talking through a wall. They'll hear the wall, too. That can't be helped." He counts it off on dust fingers, the way a landlord goes through a lease. "You keep what you carried nearest your heart. Nothing else. Don't ask me to bend that. I don't know how."

"That's it?"

"That's a great deal. I've been generous. You'll see."

"Why me?"

He goes quiet.

I'd thought the quiet before was quiet. It wasn't. Somewhere behind me a dune sighs, a slow collapse, a thousand small forgotten things settling. He looks past me, down the slope, at the glasses with the taped arm.

Then he says, in my mother's voice, exactly, the pitch and the catch in it and all:

"*Don't let them forget his name.*"

I'm on my feet. I don't remember getting there.

"She said it to me first," he says, in his own voice again. "On the grass. She was more polite about it than you've been."

"Whose name? *Whose?* What did she—"

"Simple?" the god says, and the dust finally manages a mouth, and it's smiling. "We shall see."

The dune behind him comes apart. Not falling. Lifting. A wall of gold grains rising into that colourless sky and bending toward me like a wave that's made up its mind, and I get one breath, and it's full of other people's lost things.

Then it's on me, and I'm going down, and I'm going *in*.

My sleeves swallow my hands. My collar slides past my chin. Something is folding me up like a letter, shorter and shorter, and the

blazer is a tent and then it isn't anywhere, and the last sound before the sound of all that sand is small and patient and very close to my ear.

*Tick.*

Light.

White, flat, enormous light, and heat with it, and a smell so thick it has texture.

Fish. Smoke. River.

THEBES. MIDDAY.

The heat has its hand on the back of my neck before I've opened my eyes.

I'm lying on packed earth in a slot between two walls. Mud brick, the colour of a loaf, close enough on either side that I could touch both if my arms were longer. They don't seem to be. A strip of sky runs along the top of the slot, and it's a blue I've only seen on paint charts.

I sit up, and the ground is very close to my face.

That's not a figure of speech. I'm sitting, and the earth is right there, and my knees are right there, and they're the wrong knees. Round. Scabbed on the left. Bare, under a pair of shorts too faded to have been bought this decade.

Above the shorts, a blue shirt with red sleeves, and a label inside the collar scratching the exact place on my neck it used to scratch when I was ten.

I'd forgotten the label. The body hadn't.

My hands are a child's. Short fingers, no calluses, a bitten thumbnail I stopped biting at thirteen. The bracelet my mother wove for me, red once, now the colour of rust, is still on my left wrist, but it's slack. It turns around the bone when I move.

*You keep what you carried nearest your heart.*

There's paper in the breast pocket. I take it out and look at it for a while. A ten-thousand-yen note, folded in half and in half again. The old man printed on it looks back with the expression of someone who has also been having a strange morning.

"Okay," I say, to see.

What comes out is a little boy's voice. Clear and high, and so exactly like a recording of myself at ten that my skin crawls.

I put the bill back. I put my hand flat on the warm wall. Then I stand, which takes two tries, because my balance is sitting about forty centimetres lower than I keep it, and I walk toward the noise at the end of the slot.

◆

The noise is a market, and the market is the biggest thing I've ever stood at the edge of.

Linen awnings on poles, hundreds of them, sagging in the heat, sloping down a long dusty square toward a river. The river is brown and slow and so wide the far bank is a line. Barges sit against a stone wharf, low in the water, and men with sacks on their shoulders go up the steps in a chain, singing something with a lot of the same word in it.

Past the river, a strip of green so bright it hurts. Past the green, desert. Past the desert, a wall of pale cliff.

I know the cliffs. I've seen them in a hundred photographs, the ones taken from the air, with the little road snaking in. I've never seen them from the wrong side.

Upriver, a stone wall as high as an apartment block runs along the bank, and behind it stands a needle. One shaft of stone with its point sheathed in something that throws the sun back like a signal. The textbooks had it grey and pitted. Nobody told me it was ever this.

My mother would have told me the name of the city, and she'd have used the old one, because she didn't believe in letting the Greeks have the last word.

*Waset.* The city of Amun. The god's house, behind that wall, with the sun on its tip.

So the river is the Nile, and this is Thebes, and the god in the dunes wasn't exaggerating when he said he'd choose.

Something lands on my cheek. A fly. I brush it off and another takes its place, and I think, with the part of my brain that was doing past papers eleven hours ago, that there is nothing in any book that prepares you for the flies.

◆

I go in.

A market is mostly knees when you're this high. Linen kilts, bare brown legs, the swinging edge of a basket. A woman in a white sheath dress goes by with a jar on her head and doesn't look down. A man with two live geese by the necks nearly walks into me and swears at the geese.

Boys my size run between the stalls with their heads shaved except for one braid over the right ear. I've seen that on tomb walls a thousand times and never once on a living kid. Here it's on all of them, and I'm aware for the first time of the untidy hair on my own head, and don't yet know the half of it.

The shouting turns into words without my noticing when. A man with fish laid out on wet leaves swears they were swimming at dawn. Two women argue over a copper weight, and one of them uses a word I know from a glossary and have never heard said aloud. The beer stall smells like bread that's gone wrong.

Every word reaches me a half-beat late and lands heavy, like it was thrown.

*It'll feel like talking through a wall.*

The bread is what finds me.

The smell comes from under a stained awning, where a thick-armed woman is lifting flat loaves off the side of a clay oven with her bare fingers and stacking them. Rough brown bread with ash on the bottom. On the counter beside her, a wide blue-glazed jar, cracked down one side and brimming with water, and three cups.

I stop. The counter comes to my chest. My stomach makes a noise it hasn't made since I was small, because this body has never eaten, not once, and would like to start.

I lean on the counter and look into the jar to see how bad I look.

A child looks back.

Round face. Soft chin. Skin that's never seen a sun like this one. Hair falling over the forehead in rough yellow pieces, actually yellow, the colour of wheat in a museum painting.

The eyes are blue.

My eyes are brown. My eyes have always been brown.

There's one thing in the water I recognise. A white nick through the left eyebrow.

I don't jerk back. I hold on to the counter and look at the stranger with my scar until the water settles and the stranger looks steadily back.

*They see a child,* I think. *Fine. So do I.*

"You're putting your fingers in my water."

The woman. Flour to the elbows, a tattoo of a cat on the inside of one wrist.

"I'm sorry." My voice is a little bell. "One loaf, please."

Her face changes. The way you'd look at a goat if it said *please.*

"Says please. Where's your mother?"

"I'm on my own."

"What've you got, then?"

Barter. There are no coins here. Nobody's thought of them yet. Grain, linen, copper by the deben if you're rich, and I have none of those things, and I'm so hungry my hands are shaking.

There's a very small, very stupid voice in me that is ten years old. It says: *money is money. Show her.*

I take out the bill, unfold it, and hold it up.

◆

She takes it between a floury finger and thumb and holds it to the light.

"What's this?"

"Money. Where I'm from."

"Where's that?"

I say nothing.

She turns it over. The old man in his high collar looks up at her. She squints at the numbers, and the lettering, and the little oval of colour in the corner, and her mouth goes tight.

"Whose face is this? Is this a king? He's got no crown." She holds it out sideways without looking. "Hor. What's this writing?"

Hor, with the fish, doesn't know. Neither does the woman with the figs, nor the two wet porters from the wharf, nor the old man who was buying bread when I came up and has been staring at my hair with his loaf forgotten in his hands.

They all come anyway. That's how a crowd works. One person points and twenty come to see what the pointing is for.

"Not papyrus."

"Look at the *colours* on it."

"Look at *him.* Look at his hair."

"*Khat-su,*" somebody says. It means sand-foreign. From the way he says it, it means *trash the wind blew in.*

"Spy," says somebody else, and that one travels.

*Spy for who? Hatti. They've got yellow-haired ones up there. They send children now. Who looks at a child? Get the temple men, the temple's right there—*

"I'm not a spy," I say, and nobody hears, because it's the voice of a ten-year-old and there are thirty people talking.

Over the heads I see two long staves coming, held upright, and under them two shaved heads and two spotless white kilts. Not soldiers. Not police. The granary with the ram-headed seals on its jars is thirty metres away, and these are the men who guard the god's grain, and they move through the crowd the way you move through tall grass.

The bread woman is already holding my bill out to them.

*That's mine,* I think, uselessly.

The first stave comes down, and I'm not under it.

◆

Nine years of fencing, and all it's good for in this body is knowing which way to fall.

I go low, because I'm already low. Under the fig woman's basket, between the porters, past a donkey that doesn't care. A stave cracks on the counter behind me and the bread woman shouts about her jar. The temple men shout too, for people to make way, and people never make way fast enough. That's the one thing that's the same everywhere.

At the top of the wharf steps, a cart lies tipped on its side with its axle snapped, and a man squats beside it arguing with the wood. The

broken end sticks out at the height of a grown man's shins.

I put both hands on it as I pass and shove.

It swings across the gap behind me. There's a sound like a sack of onions hitting the ground, and a great deal of swearing.

The second man comes round the cart from the other side.

There's nothing past me but the edge of the wharf and the drop.

I'd like to say I thought about it.

I go off the edge, and for a second there's nothing, and then the mud takes me to the knees. Cold. Black. It stinks of everything the river has ever been fed. I pitch forward onto my hands, and the stink is in my mouth, and when I lift my head there's a man standing in the shallows a few metres off with his kilt hitched round his thighs, rinsing mud off his shins, who has stopped rinsing to look at me.

Leather cap. A spear leaning on the wall beside him. A cowhide shield on the mud, black and white patches like a dairy cow. The look of a man who was enjoying a moment to himself.

My right hand goes to my hip, where a sword has never been, and finds shorts.

I try the thing anyway. The one thing I know. Weight back, feint left, go right.

My feet don't come out of the mud.

He doesn't even step. He puts one arm out and collects me by the front of my shirt the way you'd collect a bag someone threw at you, and holds me out at arm's length while I kick, and looks up at the top of the wall, where two white kilts have appeared.

"Yours?" he says.

"Temple's. He stole from the god's market."

"He paid with the Hittite's writing," the soldier says, as if correcting a child. "I heard it from here. Enemy writing goes to the palace. Go back to your grain."

The temple men look at each other.

Then they go back to their grain.

That's a whole lesson, and I've just had it hanging in the air by my shirt.

The spear butt in the stomach is almost an afterthought. He doesn't swing it. He brings it up to stop me kicking, and this body folds around it like a wet towel, and the air goes out of me so completely that for a moment I think it isn't coming back.

I'm on my face in the mud again.

"Stay," he says, like you'd say it to a dog, and goes to get the rope.

◆

They tie my wrists in front of me with cord that bites, and walk me back up through the market, and I'll say this for being arrested in a crowd: it's a good way to see who's who.

People get out of the soldier's way without being asked. The city police at the corner, the Medjay, with their wrist bands and their patience, nod to him, and he doesn't nod back.

He steps aside, though, for a man in long white linen with a leopard skin over one shoulder, head and all, the small dead face lolling at his hip. The soldier drops his eyes. The priest doesn't trouble to notice.

At the granary gate a scribe sits cross-legged with a palette on his knees and makes a mark for every sack that goes in, and every sack is stamped with the same ram's head, and the man standing over the scribe isn't a soldier or a policeman. He's in white.

*Whoever owns the grain,* my father used to say, usually when somebody at a dinner party had made the mistake of asking him about Egypt, *owns Egypt. Everything else is theatre.*

The temple owns the grain. The soldier owns the temple's men, when it comes to it. Somebody owns the soldier.

I count, because I can't stop. Two hundred and forty paces from the wharf to the lane I woke up in. Three turns. One gate, two guards. One cracked blue jar.

The bread woman, when we pass her, doesn't look at me. She's counting the cups.

Nobody looks at me. They look at the rope. A boy on a rope is a story they already know.

*They see a child.* I keep saying it, like a hand on a rail. *They see a child, and a child is nothing, and nothing is the safest thing in this city to be.*

At the far end of the market there's a second wharf, and a low boat with a reed canopy, and a crew who've been waiting in the shade and aren't pleased to be fetched out of it. The soldier lifts me in by the back of the shirt and sets me down among the ropes.

We push off.

The water is wide and slow and full of light. The city slides back behind us with its wall and its gold needle. Ahead, past the green, there's a long low palace of white and painted columns, built right at the lip of the desert, on the side of the river where the Egyptians put their dead.

The sun is going down behind the cliffs. They turn the colour of a peach.

Somewhere behind those cliffs, in a dry valley with a road snaking into it, every king on my mother's chart is lying in the dark.

The one I'm being taken to isn't there yet.

I sit in the bottom of the boat with my tied hands between my knees and watch the cliffs change colour, and I don't think about anything at all, as hard as I can.

THE PALACE. LATE AFTERNOON.

The soldier doesn't bother with the ladder.

The cell is a square pit cut into rock under some back corner of the palace, with a wooden grate across the top and a ladder that lives on the outside. He gets me under the arms, holds me out over the hole the way you'd hold a bag over a bin, and lets go.

It's about three metres. I land on my hip and my shoulder and the side of my head, in that order, and the grate bangs shut above me while I'm still finding out which part hurts most.

A bar slides. Sandals walk away.

I lie where I landed. The floor is stone and cool, which is the first good thing that's happened to me today. There's a square of light from the grate lying on the far wall, with the shadow of the bars across it.

I am, I notice in a distant way, crying. This body does it without consulting me. Hot and steady and without any sound.

*Soren,* I think. Just the name. Sunday was going to be three years, and I wasn't going to go, and now I'm not going to go in a way I can't take back.

Six books in brown paper on a shelf at the back of a tea shop.

A broom, stopped.

"That's a long way to fall, for someone so small."

I go still.

There's a man sitting against the far wall with his knees drawn up. I hadn't seen him. He's old, seventy at least, thin, bare-headed, with the grey stubble of a shaved scalp that's been let go for a day or two. His kilt was good linen once. His hands are loose in his lap, untied.

"I didn't see you," I say.

My voice comes out formal. It does that when I'm frightened. Every word set down carefully, like stepping stones.

His eyebrows go up. "You talk like a scribe's grandfather."

"I was raised by old people."

He laughs. It's dry and kind and doesn't last. "What did you do, grandfather?"

"I tried to buy bread."

"With what?"

"The wrong thing."

He laughs again, longer this time, and then has to wipe his eyes with the heel of his hand, and I realise he's been crying too, and is better at hiding it.

"And you?" I ask.

He's quiet a while.

"I asked a question," he says. "An order came down under the king's seal, taking the river gangs out of my district and giving them to the god's house for the building. In the month the dykes must be cut. So I went to the hall, and I knelt, and I asked the Lord of the Two Lands whether it was his own word."

"That's all?"

"That's all." He looks at his hands. "You'd be surprised what *all* costs, in there."

*He didn't ask if the order was fair,* I think. *He asked who wrote it. He thinks it wasn't the king.*

My father used to say the only dangerous question in any court was *who actually decided this?* He said it at dinner, cheerfully, with his mouth full. I don't think he ever expected anyone to find out.

"What happens now?" I ask.

"Now they weigh my heart."

He says it the way you'd say it's going to rain.

"They'll put a feather on one side and a stone on the other, and the stone will go down, because it's a stone, and the priest will say I'm heavy with disorder, and then someone will do the rest in the shadow where the king can't quite see." He shrugs, a small old man's shrug. "And after, somebody will go to my tomb with a chisel and take my name off the wall, so the gods can't find me when I call."

"They do that?"

"That's the real death, grandfather. Not the blade. Being nobody's to remember."

*Don't let them forget his name.*

I don't say anything. There isn't anything.

"I taught him to ride," the old man says, after a while, not to me. "The boy. He was six. His hands were good. Light on the reins. I told him so, and he was so pleased he told the whole court."

He goes quiet again.

I sit down beside him with my back to the wall, and neither of us says another word until the gong sounds above us, one slow note, and the stone takes it up and holds it long after it should have stopped.

◆

Two men come for us. Palace men, in better linen, with the bored, careful hands of people who move prisoners for a living.

They bring the old man up the ladder first. They lift me after him, and we go together.

Across a courtyard where the light is turning gold and a girl is scattering water on the paving against the dust. Through a kitchen court that smells of goose fat and smoke, where a boy my size turning a spit sees my hair and forgets to turn it. Along a colonnade where servants flatten themselves against the painted wall to let us pass and keep their eyes on the floor the whole way.

Through a pair of cedar doors so tall they have smaller doors cut into them for ordinary use.

Then the hall.

I've seen the ruins. Columns broken off at the knee, the paint gone, the floor dust. You stand there and tilt your head back and try to picture the roof, and you can't, not really. Nobody can.

This is what you were trying to picture.

A forest made of stone. Two rows of columns as thick as the cherry tree march away from me into lamplight, each one painted as a bundle of lotus stems in blue and green and white, the flowers opening at the top. Over the flowers, a ceiling, gold, a long way up, with the smoke of a hundred bronze lamps hanging under it in sheets.

The smoke is myrrh. I know the smell from the museum shop, where they sold it in little bags. It's the same and it's nothing like it, the way a photograph of the sea is like the sea.

Men stand between the columns. Dozens. White linen, wide gold collars, heavy black wigs. They stand without talking, the way people wait outside an exam hall, and every one of them turns his head as we come in.

The floor is painted.

That's what gets me, if I'm honest. Not the gold. Somebody plastered this entire floor and painted a marsh on it. Blue water and bending reeds, fish turning in the water, ducks going up out of the papyrus with their wings wide. It's one of the most beautiful things I've ever seen, and I'm walking across it on a rope with river mud drying between my toes.

A hand lands on the back of my neck and puts me down on it.

"Smell the earth before the Lord of the Two Lands."

My nose is on a painted duck.

◆

I keep my face down. But you can see a long way along a floor, between people's legs, and you can hear everything.

A staff hits the stone three times somewhere ahead.

A herald reads out titles. A great many. *Strong bull, perfect of birth. He of the Two Ladies. Golden Horus. Lord of Appearances.* I know the shape of them from the chart. Then he gets to the names that go in the ovals, and the throne name comes first, and it's one I can see in my mother's writing with my eyes shut.

*Nebkheperure.*

I stop breathing. I don't choose to.

My father's hand on my shoulder in front of the glass. *He was your age, Kael.* Nine. And the other date, at the bottom of the box. The one I can't see the number nineteen without.

They take the old man forward first.

He goes on his knees at the foot of the dais. I can see him along the floor. Somebody has set his wig down beside him, and beside the wig, a long fan on a gilded pole with one white ostrich plume, which must have been his, and which somebody has decided he can look at but not hold.

His hands are shaking. They weren't, in the pit.

"The fan-bearer on the king's right," says a voice I haven't heard yet, "came before this hall and asked whether the king's seal was the king's word."

The voice is soft. That's the first thing about it. Soft and deep and perfectly polite, like a host at a dinner, and it doesn't need to be loud, because the whole hall has already leaned toward it. I understand before I've seen the man that this is what everyone else in the room is arranged around.

"He asked the Lord of the Two Lands, to his face, in his own hall, whether the Lord of the Two Lands is lying."

A pause with nothing hurried in it.

"Order before mercy. Weigh him."

◆

A priest comes out from between the columns with a thing I've seen in paint a hundred times and never in bronze.

A balance. Two little pans on chains from a bar, on a stand about as high as my chest. He sets it on the painted water in front of the old man, and from a box he takes a single white feather and lays it in one pan, and from the same box a stone, red, roughly carved into the shape of a heart, and lays it in the other.

The Weighing. The heart against the feather of truth. I could draw the tomb painting from memory. The jackal-headed god steadying the scale. The ibis-headed one writing down the result. The monster with the crocodile's face waiting by the pans with her mouth open for the hearts that come up heavy.

It's a thing that happens to the dead. In the underworld. That's the whole point of it.

Nobody in this room is dead yet.

The stone goes down. Of course it does. It's a stone, and the other pan has a feather in it. There's no trick to it that I can see, and that's the trick. Nobody in this hall is waiting to find out what the scale says. They're waiting for the scale to say it, so that it was the god and not them.

The priest's eyes go to the soft-voiced man before he speaks. Just for a second. Then:

"Heavy. The heart is heavy with disorder."

A murmur between the columns, low, the sound a congregation makes.

"Ammit take it."

"Ammit take it."

The old man doesn't get up, and he doesn't shout. He looks up the steps of the dais, past the soft voice, at whoever is sitting above it, and he says, clearly, in the voice you'd use to remind a child of a promise:

"Nebkheperure. I held your reins."

Two guards take him under the arms.

He doesn't fight them. That's the part I'll have trouble with later. He's seventy and he counts dykes for a living and he knows exactly where this ends, and he lets them walk him, and he looks back over his shoulder the whole way, until the shadow between the columns takes him.

The sound is wet, and heavy, and once.

A girl comes out of the same shadow with a bucket and a rag and gets down on her knees at the edge of the lamplight and starts on the floor. The rag going back and forth is the only sound in the hall, and nobody is in any hurry to cover it.

I've got both my tied hands flat on the painted water. It's the only way to keep them still.

*An hour ago he was telling me about a boy with good hands on the reins.*

*He asked who wrote the order. That's what they killed him for. So who wrote it?*

◆

"The foreigner."

I'm hauled up onto my knees.

The soldier from the river steps forward and bows to the man standing at the throne's left hand. "Commander Nakhtmin. Taken at the god's market by the river. He paid for bread with this."

He has my bill. He holds it up by one corner, crumpled, stained brown with mud, and the hall leans in the way the market leaned in, and I hear the same words going round, as if the market had sent them ahead on the boat.

*What is it. Whose face. Not papyrus. That's cipher. Hittite. Look at his hair. A child. A child's the perfect spy. Who looks at a child.*

"Majesty." A heavy man with a heavier collar steps out and bows until his wig nearly brushes the painted reeds. "The law is plain. A foreigner taken inside the city with the enemy's writing in his hand. Let his heart be weighed."

"Let his heart be weighed," say the columns.

The priest hasn't moved the balance. The stone and the feather are still sitting where they were. He steps back to it and puts his hand on the bar.

*He didn't even reset it,* I think. *He isn't going to.*

I count without wanting to. Eleven men between me and the doors, and I couldn't outrun one of them. Two more at the doors. The guards who took the old man are coming back out of the shadow, wiping their hands.

The soft voice says nothing. I look for it now.

He's standing at the foot of the dais, at the throne's right hand. The tallest man in the room and the thinnest, so thin the indigo robe hangs off his shoulders like it's on a hook. Gold thread all over it in small figures that I know, with a lurch, are the god's name, Amun, over and over.

His head is shaved and gleams, with one band of gold across the brow. Three scars on each cheekbone, too even to be anything but on

purpose. A collar of blue lapis and red carnelian. A tall staff with a falcon's head.

His hands are wrapped in strips of linen, like a man with burns, and over the linen he wears rings. More rings than fingers.

The eyes are light. Hazel, nearly gold in the lamps. They move round the room, resting nowhere, the way a man reads a page he's read before.

"The Vizier," someone whispers near my shoulder. "Amenhotep."

I go through the chart. Twice, fast, every name in my mother's handwriting. There's a God's Father called Ay, who I'd have expected to be standing exactly where this man is standing. There's a general. There are viziers somewhere in the small print, and I don't have their names, and this one isn't ringing anything.

*So either my parents were wrong, or I'm in a room with a man history forgot to write down.*

*And I just watched what happens to people who get written down.*

Beside the Vizier, at the throne's other hand, stands the Commander. A broad young man, early twenties, black hair pulled back so hard it must hurt, a curved bronze sword at his hip, a scar along the jaw. Eyes that look about forty. He hasn't moved since I came in. I'm not sure he's blinked.

The priest's hand is on the bar.

*Think.* My heart is going so hard I can see it at the edges of my eyes. *What does a child have that a man doesn't? Not pity. You watched pity leave. Not mercy. Mercy got its heart weighed. What have you got?*

"I'm not a spy."

It rings. That's the trouble with this voice. It's a bell, and the hall was built to carry a bell.

And it comes out wrong. I can hear it coming out wrong, the way the court hears it. The sentences too built. The words too old. The pauses in the places a man puts them, out of a face with the softness still in it. A little boy who's swallowed a scribe.

"I came from very far away. I was robbed on the road and left in your city with nothing. That paper is the only thing I have, and I would never in my life—"

The hand on my neck hits me across the back of the head, hard enough that the hall goes white and comes back.

"You don't speak before the king unless the king bids you."

But it isn't the slap the room is reacting to. It's the voice. Two men step back from me. One makes a sign with his fingers against something. And the Vizier's light eyes have stopped going round the room, and settled, for the first time, on me.

I lift my head anyway. There's nowhere else to put it.

Up the steps of the dais. Past the indigo robe and the rings. Past the young man with the sword.

The throne is gold. All of it. Gold leaf over carved wood, lion heads at the ends of the arms, lion feet, and across the back a pair of wings worked in blue stone and red stone with a sun disc between them. It's the one from the glass case. I'd know it anywhere. It was built for a god, or a man wanting to be sat in like one, and it's enormous.

The boy sitting in it doesn't fill the seat.

He's nine. I've known he was nine since I was six. He's slight and fine-boned and brown, with a narrow, serious face. The striped blue-and-gold cloth of the nemes falls to his shoulders, the gold cobra rearing off his brow, and someone has tied a braided false beard to his chin on a cord that's rubbed him red under the jaw. A collar of gold and lapis covers his thin chest like a breastplate.

His feet don't reach the footstool. They hang above it in small gold sandals. The footstool is painted, like everything here is painted, and what's painted on it is a row of foreigners on their faces with their arms bound behind them, so that when the king's feet do reach, they'll rest on his enemies.

On his collar there's a scarab of black stone, pinned. His fingers are closed around it so hard the knuckles have gone pale.

He isn't looking at me, or at the priest, or at the stained bill. He's looking at the Vizier. He has the look I've seen on every kid in every classroom I've ever sat in: watching the teacher's face to find out what the answer is going to be.

*He didn't give the order,* I think. *The old man was right. And the boy knows he was right, and he sat there.*

*He's nine. He's sitting on a chair built for someone twice his size, with the man who taught him to ride being scrubbed off the floor in front of him.*

The priest's hand tightens on the bar.

The king of Egypt turns his head, as if someone has said his name, and looks down the steps, and finds a muddy foreign boy on his knees looking straight back up at him.

Neither of us looks away.

His eyes are dark and ringed with black paint and much too tired for nine. For a long moment he just looks, the way you'd catch your own reflection in a shop window and not be sure, for a second, that it's you.

Then his fingers come off the scarab.

The king raises one hand.

He doesn't stand. He doesn't say anything. He lifts his right hand off the lion's head on the arm of the throne, palm out, not high, the

way you'd ask to go to the bathroom in a classroom where asking was frowned on.

The priest stops with his hand on the scale.

I've been in rooms that went quiet. This one does something else. Sixty grown men in gold collars take the same half-breath and hold it, and every one of them, I watch it happen, lets his eyes slide off the raised hand and down the steps to the foot of the dais, to find out what it means.

The Vizier doesn't move. He doesn't look up at the boy. He stands with his falcon staff and his rings and his three scars a side, and his face is pleasant and interested, like a man watching a child try to open a jar.

"Wait," the king says.

The voice is high and thin and shouldn't carry. It carries. It's the voice I've heard described by narrators in a dozen documentaries, and now it's just a boy's voice in a big room, and it wobbles.

"Majesty." The heavy man bows again, so deep I can see the sweat on the back of his neck. "Lord of the Two Lands. The weighing is the law. A foreigner with the enemy's—"

"I heard."

Two words. Flat. The way a child says *I heard* when he's been told to put his shoes on for the third time.

"Bring him up."

◆

The hand on my neck lifts me and walks me forward, across the painted water, past the girl with the rag, who doesn't look up, until I'm standing at the bottom of the steps with my tied hands in front of me and the gold footstool with its painted prisoners at the level of my eyes.

Up close he's smaller still.

His wrists are sticks inside the gold. The false beard is too heavy for his face and pulls his chin down. Under the kohl there are shadows, the real kind, the kind you get from lying awake. He smells of myrrh and, under it, of something ordinary and warm, bread or milk, a little boy's smell.

He looks down at me from the throne of Egypt. I look back, and I don't lower my eyes.

I should. Everything I've learned in three years of offices and interviews says drop them, be small, be sorry. But I'm already small. I've never in my life been smaller. And I've just about run out of sorry.

So I look at him, and he looks at me. My muddy yellow hair. The strange shirt. The rope. The cut in my eyebrow.

Then he says, clearly, pitched to reach the back of the hall:

"I shall sentence you."

The priest's hand comes off the scale.

"By my royal authority," the king says, "I declare you to be my royal playmate. And pet."

◆

For a second nobody gets it.

I don't get it. The words arrive the half-beat late they always do, and I have to hear them twice before they'll sit still.

*Playmate.*

The second one takes longer.

Then the hall gets it, and the sound it makes isn't loud, courtiers don't shout, but it goes down the columns like something spilled. Shock. A kind of disgust. Two short laughs, strangled off behind hands.

The heavy man has gone red to the wig. “Majesty, with respect. The boy is a foreigner. He is possibly a sorcerer. He cannot simply be *kept*, like a—”

“He is mine now.”

“Majesty, the weighing—”

“Pharaoh has sentenced.”

He says it louder. Not much. The voice breaks clean in half on *Pharaoh*, and his hand has gone back to the black scarab on his collar and shut on it, and I can see from here that it’s shaking.

He’s terrified.

He’s nine years old and he’s terrified and he’s doing it anyway. And I feel something I haven’t felt since I was fifteen and watching my own house burn, which is that I would like, very much, to put myself between somebody and a thing.

*He can’t stop the weighing,* I think. *He isn’t allowed. Everyone in this room knows he isn’t allowed. So he’s found the one sentence a king can pass that nobody can carry out with a knife, because you can’t execute the king’s property, and he’s passed it before anyone could tell him no.*

*That isn’t a child’s trick. That’s a lawyer’s.*

The silence after *Pharaoh has sentenced* goes on long enough to hurt.

Every face in the hall turns, not fast, to the foot of the dais.

The Vizier lets them look. He lets the boy’s hand shake on the scarab one more time. Then he bows, and it’s a lovely thing, the staff dipping, the rings going down in a wave.

“The Lord of the Two Lands has spoken,” he says softly, to the room, “and his word is the seal. A toy for the king.” A pause. “Order before mercy. But a toy costs the Two Lands nothing.”

He straightens.

He hasn't said a word to me, and he doesn't now. But as he comes up out of the bow, his eyes come to me and stay, and they narrow a little, the way a man's do when the print is small and he's decided it's worth the trouble of reading.

I've been looked at by a lot of adults. Teachers. Detectives. The uncle in Osaka, measuring how much of his spare room I'd take up. I know what it looks like when someone sees a kid.

This isn't it.

*Noted,* I think. *I've been noted.*

The scribe at the foot of the steps holds up my bill. The Vizier takes it between two linen-wrapped fingers and looks at the old man's face on it for exactly as long as he looked at mine.

"Enter it," he says, "and keep it with the records of this hall. Things from nowhere should be kept where they can be found again."

The scribe bows and lays my ten thousand yen in a cedar box, and shuts the lid.

The last piece of the world I came from, in a box, in a palace, and it was the Vizier who decided where.

"Nakhtmin."

The wall beside the throne moves. The Commander comes down the steps and stands over me, and I find out he's even bigger from below.

"Cut the rope."

"It will be done."

There's nothing in the voice. No heat, no cold. The curved sword comes out and goes down between my wrists before I've seen him draw, and the cord falls in two pieces, and I felt the bronze go by. It didn't touch skin. He was never going to let it.

He sheathes the sword and goes back up to his place and doesn't look at me again.

I rub my wrists. *That was a measurement,* I think. *He wanted to know if I'd flinch. I don't know yet whether it was good or bad that I didn't.*

◆

The far doors bang.

A man comes in between the columns at a run that's become a stagger, grey with dust from his hair to his feet, two guards half holding him up. He reaches the edge of the lamplight, goes down on his face, kisses the painted reeds, and gets his message out before the herald has drawn breath.

"Majesty. From the north. The men of Hatti have come down again. Another city that sent tribute to Kemet has opened its gates to them, and its prince has sworn to their king. The road past it is shut."

The hall comes apart.

Now they shout. Men in gold push forward between the columns, all at once, all over each other.

*Hatti again. That's the third this year. Send the army. There's no army to send, the treasury's empty, the god's house has had it all for the building. Then take it back from the god's house. You'd take from Amun?*

The Vizier lifts his staff. Not high. A hand's width.

It stops.

"The council will hear the messenger," he says. "Privately. The king is tired."

Nobody asks the king if he's tired.

I've stopped listening to the Vizier. I'm standing at the foot of the dais with the rope off and mud drying on my legs, and my mother's chart is unrolling itself down the wall over my bed, with all her small notes in the margins.

*Letters from the vassal kings, begging. "Send archers." "Send archers." Nobody sends archers.*

*Suppiluliuma. The Hittite. Takes everything north of the river that the last two kings let slip.*

*The stela this boy puts up in the temple, with his own name on it. "If an army was sent to Djahy to widen the borders of Egypt, it had no success."*

*No success.*

I know this.

I don't know the day, or the city, or the name of the prince who just changed sides. But I know which way this reign leans, because I was raised by two people who had read the end of it. I know what gets carved on the walls and what gets cut off them afterward with chisels. I know the number at the bottom of the box.

Sixty men in this room are shouting about what happens next, and not one of them knows.

I do.

*A child can't hold a sword,* I think, and my hands have started shaking again, and it isn't fear this time. *A child can't sit on the council, or ask who wrote the order. But a child who knows what's coming—*

*—would be worth keeping. For a while.*

◆

"Come here."

It's very quiet. It's for me.

The court is still loud over the messenger. Nobody is watching the steps. I go up two, three, until I'm beside the painted footstool and the gold sandals hanging above it, and the king of Egypt leans down off his father's throne until his face is near mine.

"What are you called?"

"Kael."

He tries it. "Kael." Carefully, like a word in somebody else's language. The sound of it in that voice goes through me, because it's the first time anyone in this whole world has said my name.

Then, lower:

"Do you know senet?"

"No."

"Good." His eyes go, for half a second, to the Vizier's back, and come back to me. "Learn slowly."

That's all. He sits back. The tired, frightened, nine-year-old face closes like a box and goes polite and empty, and he looks out over his shouting court as if I've been dismissed, and maybe I have.

I stand on the step with that in my ears.

*Learn slowly.*

He wants a playmate who loses. A playmate who loses is harmless, and a harmless thing is a thing nobody troubles to take away from a child. He's just told me how to stay alive, in three words, in front of all of them, and not one of them heard it, because who listens to a little boy asking his toy if it can play a game.

I came up those steps thinking I'd found the one other person in the room as trapped as me.

I was right. I just hadn't thought through what a trapped thing learns to do.

◆

The soldier from the river takes me out.

He doesn't drag me. He walks, and I follow, because I'm property now, and that's what property does.

As we pass between the columns, a man in a wig leans to the man beside him and says, not very quietly, “The Pharaoh’s toy.” The other one laughs into his hand.

I count.

A hundred and twelve paces from the hall doors. Left at a painted pillar. Right past a court with a dry fountain. Down three steps into a corridor where the plaster is bare and the doors are plain, and the air smells of lamp oil and old bread.

Servants’ rooms. Close enough to the hall to be sent for.

He stops at a cedar door and pushes it open with his foot. The room behind is as narrow as a man’s arms spread. A reed mat. A clay bowl of water on the floor. A window slit high up, with the last of the light coming through it red and lying across the mat like a cut.

He puts a hand between my shoulders and shoves, not hard, and I go in and sit down on the mat, because my legs have decided.

There’s something under the edge of the mat. I feel for it.

A sandal. A child’s, leather, small enough that it wouldn’t go on my foot now, which is saying something. One of a pair.

I look up. The soldier is still in the doorway, watching me hold it. He’s young, I see now. Twenty, maybe. A sunburnt nose. Not cruel, I think. Just someone who stopped expecting things to go well a while ago and has got comfortable there.

“That one lasted eleven days,” he says.

He pulls the door shut. A bar goes across it, on the outside.

◆

I sit on the mat in the dark with the sandal in my lap.

The red bar of light climbs the wall and goes purple and goes out. Somewhere above me the gong sounds again, once, and the stone

keeps it, and when it's finally gone I can hear my own breathing, which is small and fast and belongs to a child.

The blue shirt is stiff with mud. There's myrrh in my hair and river on my skin and under it, I swear, faint, old smoke. From the books. From the house.

*Eleven days.*

*Learn slowly.*

Somewhere in this palace a man with linen on his fingers has decided which box I belong in. Somewhere a priest is putting a feather away for tomorrow. Somewhere a girl is wringing out a rag. Somewhere a nine-year-old is lying in a bed built for his father, deciding, with his eyes open, how long his new toy is likely to last.

And somewhere a long way off, where nothing is, a man made of dust is watching a very small hourglass.

*Tick.*

I put my knees up and my arms round them. They're very small knees.

I think about the boy on the cherry road, on his backside on the wet pavement in his blue shirt, laughing with his head back.

I think about my own voice under the tree, saying it to nobody.

I wished for a simpler life…

…and the gods gave me a palace full of people who want me dead.

◆ ◆ ◆

END OF CHAPTER 1

*Next: Chapter 2 · The Shield of the Pharaoh*